OS MCP-GEO × OPENREACH PROJECT GIGABIT

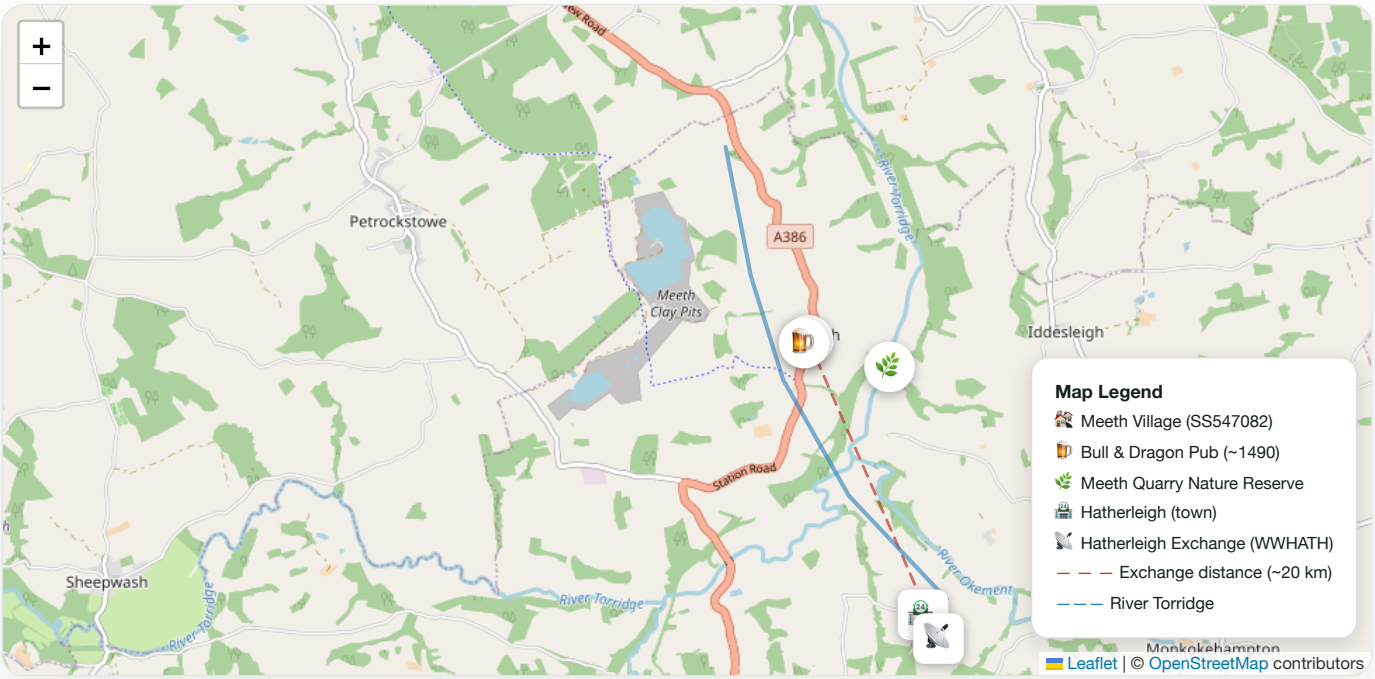
Meeth, North Devon
The UK's First Rural Openreach Intervention

West Devon parish at the heart of the UK's pioneering Project
listant telephone exchange changed everything.

1,042	20 km	3–4	Feb 2025
HECTARES	TO PARENT EXCHANGE	MBPS BEFORE FTTP	FIRST GIGABIT LIVE

📍 Location — Meeth, West Devon

OS NGD data via mcp-geo · Centred on SS547082 · 50.855°N, 4.066°W



Geographic & Administrative Profile

Source: OS Names, OS Places, Admin Lookup via mcp-geo

FIELD	DETAIL
OS Grid Reference	SS 547 082
Latitude / Longitude	50.8550°N, 4.0657°W
Classification (OS Names)	Populated Place — Village
Local Authority	West Devon Borough Council
County	Devon County Council

FIELD	DETAIL
Parish Area	1,042 hectares (2,479 acres)
Nearest Town	Hatherleigh (3 miles S), Okehampton (8.4 miles SE)
River	River Torridge (western boundary); confluence with R. Okement nearby
Telephone Exchange (Openreach)	Hatherleigh — WWHATH (Victoria Road, Hatherleigh EX20 3JG)
Exchange Enabled ADSL	December 2004
Exchange Enabled ADSL Max	March 2006
Distance to Exchange	~20 km (line route); properties 2.3 km from nearest VDSL2 cabinet

📡 Broadband Before & After Openreach FTTP

Project Gigabit Type C — first 38 communities — February 2025

BEFORE — ADSL VIA HATHERLEIGH EXCHANGE

3–4 Mbps

Hampered by 20 km line length and 2.3 km from nearest cabinet. Video calls, cloud farming systems and home working were near-impossible.

AFTER — FULL FIBRE FTTP (PROJECT GIGABIT)

1 Gbps

Gigabit-capable FTTP delivered directly to each premise. First live connections: February 2025. Bull & Dragon pub (est. ~1490) now fully connected.

PUBLIC SUBSIDY (TYPE C CALL-OFF 4)

£77m

Covers Mid Devon, North Somerset & South Devon — 37,000 premises. Part of the broader £800 million BDUK–Openreach framework agreement.

MEETH'S PLACE IN HISTORY

#1 of 38

Meeth was among only 38 communities selected for the very first wave of Project Gigabit FTTP connections — the hardest-to-reach rural premises in England.

🔌 The Distant Exchange Problem — Why Meeth Waited So Long

The copper-wire physics that left a village behind

Signal Path: Hatherleigh Exchange → Meeth Premise (Pre-FTTP)

WWHATH Exchange
Hatherleigh ~20km away

Copper pair ~17–18 km

Street Cabinet
VDSL2 cabinet 2.3 km from premise

Final copper drop

Meeth Premise
3–4 Mbps theoretical max

Openreach POP Node
Local fibre distribution point

Full fibre FTTP cable

ONT at Premise
Optical Network Termination

Fibre to the Premises

Meeth Premise
Up to 1 Gbps symmetrical

Why it matters: VDSL2 (superfast broadband) performance degrades sharply beyond ~500m from cabinet. At 2,300m from the cabinet — and with the exchange itself 20km away — ADSL attenuation was so severe that Meeth fell completely outside the reach of any viable FTTC upgrade. Only a full FTTP deployment, bypassing copper entirely, could solve it. This is precisely the "distant exchange" classification that put Meeth into the hardest-to-reach BDUK tier.

📅 Meeth — Timeline

From clay railways to gigabit fibre

1800S

Ball Clay Mining Begins

Meeth's economy built around ball clay extraction — used in tiles, sanitaryware and ceramics. Shaft and tunnel methods employed across the parish.

1925

North Devon & Cornwall Junction Light Railway

Railway opens through Meeth (Halwill Junction to Torrington), giving the clay mines direct rail access to Bideford for sea transport.

1970S

Peak Clay Production

70,000 tonnes per year extracted. Nearly 50 local jobs. Meeth's own station served the works until 1981.

1982

Railway Closes

North Devon & Cornwall Junction Light Railway ceases operation. Meeth becomes more isolated.

2004

Ball Clay Mines Close

The mines that defined the parish for two centuries shut permanently. The 150-hectare site falls silent.

2006

Hatherleigh Exchange Gets ADSL Max

Broadband arrives — theoretically. But with 20 km of copper between Meeth and the exchange, practical speeds are 3–4 Mbps at best.

2010–2016

Connecting Devon & Somerset Phase 1 (CDS)

£94m programme delivers superfast broadband to 290,000+ Devon premises — but Meeth, classed as "too distant", is left out of the FTTC rollout.

2013

Meeth Quarry Becomes a Nature Reserve

Devon Wildlife Trust purchases the 150-hectare former clay site. Wetlands, heathland and woodland established. Home to marsh fritillary butterflies and Devon's largest Goosander roost.

2020–2024

CDS Phase 2 & Airband Fixed Wireless

Some rural areas get fixed-wireless 100 Mbps via Airband. Meeth receives partial coverage, subject to survey — a significant improvement but still not universal FTTP.

2024

BDUK Awards £800m Project Gigabit Contract to Openreach

Type C framework signed. Meeth falls into Call-Off 4 (Mid Devon, North Somerset, South Devon) — 37,000 premises, £77m public subsidy. The "hardest to reach" finally in scope.

FEB 2025

🎉 First Gigabit Connections Live in Meeth

Meeth becomes one of only 38 communities in the inaugural Project Gigabit FTTP wave. The Bull & Dragon pub (est. ~1490) goes from 3 Mbps to gigabit broadband. A village transformed.

> *"We were running on 3–4 Mbps. Video calls dropped constantly, and you couldn't run the booking system and the till at the same time. Now we've got full fibre — it's genuinely changed how we run the business."*
>
> *— Mike Tunnicliffe, Landlord, The Bull & Dragon, Meeth (est. ~1490) · February 2025*

📌 Meeth at a Glance

Key facts from OS Places, OS Names & parish records

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Settlement Character

A quiet rural village classified as a "Populated Place — Village" in the OS Names dataset (ID: osgb4000000074574126). Surrounded by farmland, with the River Torridge forming a natural western boundary.

⛪

Church of St Michael & All Angels

The parish church, recently re-opened after restoration works. The village also has a hall and the Bull & Dragon pub, one of North Devon's oldest, dating from approximately 1490.

🏞️

Meeth Quarry Nature Reserve

150-hectare former ball clay mine purchased by Devon Wildlife Trust in 2013. Now features wetlands, heathland and woodland — and Devon's largest Goosander roost (50+ birds). OS Names ID: osgb4000000074821139.

🚂

Lost Railway

The North Devon & Cornwall Junction Light Railway (1925–1982) ran through Meeth, serving the clay mines with a halt at "Meeth Halt". The trackbed is now a footpath and nature corridor.

🌊

River Torridge Confluence

Meeth sits close to the confluence of the Torridge and Okement rivers. The Torridge rises on Dartmoor and flows north through the parish before reaching the estuary at Bideford — made famous by Henry Williamson's *Tarka the Otter*.

🏺

Ball Clay Heritage

Ball clay — prized for its plasticity and pale-firing properties — was extracted here for nearly 200 years. Used in high-quality ceramics, tiles and sanitaryware. At peak: 70,000 tonnes/year, ~50 jobs. Closed 2004.

🌿 Meeth Quarry Nature Reserve — Devon Wildlife Trust

150 hectares transformed from industrial clay pit to wildlife haven since 2013

🦋

Marsh Fritillary
One of the UK's most threatened butterflies, found in the reserve's wet grassland habitats.

🦆

Goosander Roost
Devon's largest — up to 50+ Goosanders roosting on Stockleigh Lake overnight in winter.

🌾

Southern Damselfly
One of Europe's rarest Odonata, breeding in the reserve's spring-fed stream systems.

🏊

Three Water Bodies
Including Stockleigh Lake — former clay lagoons now rich freshwater habitats.

🌳

Habitat Mosaic
Wetland, heath, scrub and woodland in close proximity — unusually high biodiversity density.

🦅

Waterfowl & Waders
Significant counts of teal, pochard, pintail and snipe recorded during winter surveys.

🇬🇧 Programme Context — Connecting Devon & Somerset / Project Gigabit

How Meeth fits into the national broadband story

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CDS Phase 1 (2010–2016)

£94m programme. Delivered FTTC superfast broadband (24Mbps+) to 290,000+ Devon premises. Meeth excluded — too distant from any viable FTTC cabinet.

📶

CDS Phase 2 (2020–2024)

£80m FTTP programme via Airband, Truespeed & Wessex Internet. Partial fixed-wireless coverage for some Dartmoor/Exmoor communities including parts near Meeth.

🚀

Project Gigabit Type C (2024–)

£800m BDUK–Openreach framework. Type C targets premises with zero commercial interest. 297,000 hard-to-reach UK premises. Meeth: Call-Off 4 (£77m, 37,000 premises, Mid Devon).

🏆

"First 38" Communities

Meeth was one of only 38 communities chosen for the inaugural Project Gigabit FTTP wave in February 2025, marking the first Openreach intervention in the hardest-to-reach rural tier under the new programme.

Sources & Data

- OS Names API via mcp-geo — Meeth Village (osgb4000000074574126), Meeth Quarry (osgb4000000074821139)
- OS Places API via mcp-geo — Address and UPRN data for West Devon / EX20 postcode sector
- OS Map Inventory via mcp-geo — Buildings, road links, UPRNs for bbox [-4.095, 50.84, -4.04, 50.87]
- Openreach — Full Fibre coming to rural Devon
- Comms Business — Openreach brings full fibre to 38 hard-to-reach communities
- Connecting Devon and Somerset programme
- GOV.UK — Project Gigabit framework agreement (Openreach)
- Wikipedia — Meeth
- Devon Wildlife Trust — Meeth Quarry Nature Reserve
- GENUKI Devon Parish Records — Meeth
- Hatherleigh Telephone Exchange (WWHATH) technical data

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